

Hypothesis

Individuals who have experienced violent victimization are more likely to commit violent crimes than individuals who have not experienced victimization.

Statement of the Problem

Violence is still a serious problem in many communities, and it affects both victims and offenders. In many cases, people think of victims and criminals as completely different groups. However, research shows that this may not always be true. Some people who commit crimes have also been victims of violence earlier in their lives. Victimization can include things like physical assault, abuse, bullying, or other harmful experiences. These events can affect how a person thinks, feels, and behaves. Because of this, it is important to study the connection between victimization and criminal behavior. Understanding this relationship could help researchers and policymakers find better ways to prevent violence and support people who have experienced trauma.

Researchers in criminology often talk about something called the “victim–offender overlap.” This idea suggests that people who are victims of violence are sometimes more likely to become offenders later in life. Several factors may explain this relationship, including exposure to violence, trauma, environment, and learned behavior. Jennings, Piquero, and Reingle (2012) explain that many individuals experience both victimization and offending during their lifetime. This means that the roles of victim and offender can sometimes overlap instead of being completely separate.

Even though researchers have studied this topic, there is still more to learn about why victimization may lead to offending for some people but not others. This study will examine whether individuals who have experienced victimization are more likely to commit violent crimes. Understanding this relationship could help improve crime prevention efforts and support programs for people who have experienced violence.

Source

Jennings, W. G., Piquero, A. R., & Reingle, J. M. (2012). On the overlap between victimization and offending: A review of the literature. *Aggression and Violent Behavior, 17*(1), 16–26.
<https://doi.org/10.1016/j.avb.2011.09.003>

Table 1. Studies examining the link between A and B

Citation	Key Independent & Dependent Variables	Key Findings
Lauritsen, J. L., Sampson, R. J., & Laub, J. H. (2004).	DVariable: Violent offending IVariable: Prior Victimization experience	Offenders often have histories of victimization (+) There is a clear overlap between victim and offender roles (+)
Jennings, W.G., Piquero, A.R., & Reingle, J.M. (2012).	DVariable: Violent offending IVariable: Violent victimization and prior exposure to violence	Victimization is strongly linked to later offending (+) evidence supports victim-offender overlap (+)
Fagan, J., Piper, E. S., & Moore, M. (1986)	DVariable: Violent delinquency IVariable: Exposure to violence and prior victimization	Exposure to violence increases violent behavior (+) Violence becomes normalized at an early age (+)
Widom, C. S., & Maxfield, M. G. (2001)	DVariable: Violent/Criminal behavior IVariable: Childhood abuse and neglect	Childhood victimization increases the risk of later violent offending (+). Longterm trauma impacts future behavior (+)

Research on violent behavior has started to focus more on the connection between victimization and offending instead of treating them as two completely different things. In the past, people usually saw victims and offenders as separate groups. However, newer research shows that many individuals actually fall into both categories at different points in their lives. This idea is called the victim-offender overlap, and it helps explain why some people who experience violence may later go on to commit violence themselves. Understanding this relationship is important because it can help find better ways to prevent violence instead of just punishing it.

One of the main ideas found in research is that people who are victims of violence are more likely to become offenders later on. Studies consistently show a strong connection between these two experiences. For example, Lauritsen, Sampson, and Laub (2004) found that many offenders have also been victims at some point in their lives. This shows that victimization is not just something that happens once and is over, but something that can have lasting effects. In the same way, Jennings, Piquero, and Reingle (2012) found strong evidence that people who experience violence are more likely to engage in violent behavior later. They also found that the more someone is exposed to violence, the higher their chances are of becoming an offender. When looking at both of these studies together, it becomes clear that victimization plays a major role in shaping future behavior.

Another important idea in the research is how early exposure to violence can influence a person's behavior. When someone experiences violence at a young age, they may begin to see it as normal. Fagan, Piper, and Moore (1986) found that individuals who are exposed to violence early in life are more likely to become involved in violent delinquency. This happens because repeated exposure can make violence seem like a normal way to handle problems or conflict.

Over time, this can turn into a learned behavior, especially if the person grows up in an environment where violence is common. This shows that early experiences are very important in shaping how someone behaves later in life.

Trauma is another major factor that helps explain the connection between victimization and offending. When people go through serious experiences like abuse or neglect, it can affect them for a long time. Widom and Maxfield (2001) found that individuals who experienced childhood abuse or neglect were more likely to commit crimes and engage in violent behavior as they got older. This suggests that trauma can change how a person thinks, reacts to situations, and handles emotions. Instead of being a short-term issue, victimization can have long-term effects that increase the chances of future violence.

When all of these studies are looked at together, they show a clear pattern. Victimization, early exposure to violence, and trauma all work together to increase the likelihood of violent offending. These factors are connected, not separate. For example, someone who is exposed to violence early may start to see it as normal, while trauma can affect how they respond to situations emotionally. At the same time, repeated victimization increases the chances that they will act violently. This shows that violent behavior is often influenced by past experiences instead of happening randomly.

Overall, the research strongly supports the idea that there is a connection between victimization and violent offending. Instead of only focusing on punishment, these studies suggest that helping victims and addressing their experiences early could prevent future violence. This is important because it shows that understanding the cause of behavior can lead to better solutions. By focusing on prevention and support, it may be possible to break the cycle of violence and reduce crime in the long run.

Conceptually, I define violent victimization as experiencing harmful acts such as physical assault, abuse, or bullying. I define violent offending as engaging in behaviors that involve intentionally harming others, such as fighting, assault, or threatening someone. For this study, I will measure both the independent variable (violent victimization) and the dependent variable (violent offending) using two different levels of measurement.

Independent Variable: Violent Victimization

I will use nominal measurement and ordinal measurement for this variable.

Nominal Measurement (Victimization)

Violent victimization will be measured using survey items that ask respondents whether they have experienced the following:

Have you ever been physically assaulted (hit, punched, or attacked)?

Response option: (0 = yes, 1 = no)

Have you ever been bullied or repeatedly harassed?

Response option: (0 = yes, 1 = no)

Have you ever been threatened with serious harm?

Response option: (0 = yes, 1 = no)

Ordinal Measurement (Victimization – Likert Scale)

The same concept will be measured using a Likert scale to capture severity/frequency:

I have experienced physical violence from another person.

Response option: (1 = never, 2 = rarely, 3 = sometimes, 4 = often)

I have been bullied or harassed by others.

Response option: (1 = never, 2 = rarely, 3 = sometimes, 4 = often)

I have been threatened or felt unsafe due to others.

Response option: (1 = never, 2 = rarely, 3 = sometimes, 4 = often)

Dependent Variable: Violent Offending

I will use nominal measurement and ratio measurement for this variable.

Nominal Measurement (Offending)

Violent offending will be measured by asking respondents whether they have committed the following acts:

Have you ever physically attacked or fought someone?

Response option: (0 = yes, 1 = no)

Have you ever threatened someone with harm?

Response option: (0 = yes, 1 = no)

Have you ever used force to take something from another person?

Response option: (0 = yes, 1 = no)

Ratio Measurement (Offending)

To measure the frequency of offending, respondents will be asked how many times they have engaged in these behaviors:

How many times have you physically attacked or fought someone? ()

How many times have you threatened someone? ()

How many times have you used force to take something from another person? ()

Response format: (0 = 0 times, 1 = 1 time, 2 = 2 times, 3 = 3 times, etc.)

These measurements are appropriate because using multiple levels of measurement strengthens the study by providing both basic classification and detailed data, which helps better test the relationship between victimization and offending.

References

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